

ANI

Seizing Control

- Without the Naidu-led TDP's 16 MPs, the Modi regime's majority is too close to the half-way mark for comfort
- This political comeback also saw Naidu emerge as India's seniormost chief minister, having first held the post in undivided Andhra in 1995
- His Swarn Andhra@2047 (Golden Andhra Pradesh) vision aims to transform the state into a $2.4 trillion economy in next 23 years, achieving a per capita income of $43,000 while ensuring inclusive economic development

In retrospect, they shouldn't have done that—even in pure tactical terms. The Old Fox was cornered—and since flight was out of the equation, it had to be a fight. The eyes, sharp as ever, zeroed in on the route: a tie-up with the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) would be Step 1 of Project Retribution. It unfolded like a cyclone: a near-clean sweep for the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) in the simultaneous state and parliamentary elections, with a jaw-dropping 164 of Andhra Pradesh's 175 assembly seats and 21 of its 25 Lok Sabha seats. Its individual tally of 16 LS seats also made the TDP the biggest ally of the BJP, which for the first time in the past decade found itself well short of the majority mark. Upshot: Naidu was back as a pivotal force in national politics, three decades after he first did that gig.

His fourth term as CM contains challenges, but of the sort he will relish: transforming Andhra into a global investment hub, transforming its image from an agrarian backwater to a modern, tech-driven state, the greenfield capital of Amaravati—his flagship project—as its crowning glory. As for all the political balancing acts these call for vis-a-vis New Delhi, he's a virtuoso at those. ■